An Introductory Reader

BANGLADESH

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Chapter 3

MUSLIM CONQUEST OF BENGAL

Sultanate: Society and Culture

K. M. Mohsin

Ikhtiyaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji conquered Bengal in 1204 CE and established Muslim rule from the capital at Lakhnauti. The extension of Muslim power into Bengal may be regarded as a consequence of the Muslim domination of northern India established by Muhammad Ghori. However, the Arabs had established commercial contact with Bengal, particularly the coastal areas, long before its territorial conquest by the Muslim rulers.

In fact, there are three distinct stages of the expansion of Muslim political power into the Indian subcontinent. First, during the eighth and ninth centuries CE the Arabs became the foremost maritime people in the world. The 712 CE Arab conquest of Sind and Muhan in present-day Pakistan and their settlement in the region not only expanded Arab trade in the area, but also brought Arabian Muslims into direct contact with the Indus valley. This opened the gates for the gradual expansion of Islam and the subsequent establishment of Muslim political power in the Indian Subcontinent. Second, Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni (located in present-day central Afghanistan) invaded as far eastward as Kanauj (in present-day Uttar Pradesh) and southward as Somnath in Gujarat during his seventeen expeditions, but he did not choose to consolidate his position in the areas he invaded except for a small portion of northwest India. In the third and final stage, Muhammad Ghori established a sultanate in Delhi and laid the basis for the expansion of Muslim rule throughout the subcontinent. It was after Ghori's establishment of the Muslim sultanate in Delhi that Bakhtiyar Khalji led an expedition into Bengal from his base in southern Bihar.

Ikhtiyaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji was a Turkish adventurer who came to Delhi in search of a job in the army. When his effort to obtain employment in Delhi failed, he travelled to Baduan (in present-day Uttar Pradesh) and from there he moved to Oudh (present-day Lucknow).

Malik Hushamuddin, the ruler of Oudh, offered him a *jaigir* (a type of feudal land grant) of two Parganas (Bhagwat and Vhuili) southwest of Mirzapur (in present-day Uttar Pradesh). He created a sizable army with the money obtained from these *jaigirs* and established his power-base there. He then invaded neighboring Hindu kingdoms and further strengthened his position. At one point, he occupied a Buddhist monastery called Odantapuri Vihar. The Muslims called this area *Bihar* or *Biharsharif*—and the Indian state of Bihar still bears this name.

From Bihar Bakhtiyar marched towards Bengal. He avoided the traditional Teliagharh pass (in Rajmahal, present-day Jharkhand state) to enter Bengal and instead advanced through the forest belt, *Jharkhand*. Only eighteen of his horsemen could keep pace with him by the time he reached Nadia, where Laksman Sen, the last of the Sena Kings of Bengal, was staying. Bakhtiyar and his eighteen horsemen were taken as horse dealers from North India and as such were not stopped by the city guards at any point. He went straight to the gate of the king's palace and suddenly attacked and killed the palace security forces. At that time, the old king was eating his mid-day meal; when he heard the news of the attack, he thought that the city had already been overpowered by the invaders. He hurriedly left the palace through the back door and fled by boat to his capital of Vikrampur in East Bengal. Bakhtiyar's main army soon joined the small force and captured Nadia after a siege of several days.

Bakhtiyar moved towards Lakhnauti (Gaur) and established his capital there. He then further advanced eastward and extended his principality into the Varendra area in North Bengal. The whole tract of land comprising the greater portion of Northern and Western Bengal seems to have been brought under Muslim dominion at this time. Bakhtiyar's territory in Bengal proper—not including his original *jaigirs* in Mirzapur district, southern Bihar, and the portion North of the Ganges—included the districts of Rajmahal (now in Jharkhand), Malda, Dinajpur, Rajshahi, Rangpur, and Bogra. The river system formed by the Tista-Brahmaputra-Korotoa acted as the eastern limit of the Lakhnauti principality. Bakhtiyar soon consolidated his new conquests and established military outposts in the border areas. He assigned the administration of different parts of his territory to the charge of his principal nobles and military chiefs to maintain law and order and collect revenues. It was also their duty to look after the well-being of the people under their charge. In his effort to establish a Muslim society, Bakhtiyar constructed mosques, *madrasas*

(Muslim religious schools) and *khanqahs* (shelters for sufis and saints). This practice was also followed by his subordinate officers.

The last important event in Bakhtiyar's career was his expedition to Tibet. It is difficult to ascertain his motive for undertaking such a hazardous expedition through an unconventional route while large areas of East Bengal remained outside his domain. Whatever his motives might have been, it seems that he did make adequate preparations for a Tibetan expedition, marching at the head of a large army of 10,000 cavalry through the strongholds of various tribes at the foot of the Himalayas. This expedition met with disaster, as most of his soldiers were lost during the journey in a confrontation with a hostile army. Then the main body of the army was drowned during the return journey while attempting to cross the river Baranadi near Guwahati in northern Assam. Bakhtiyar somehow managed to cross the river with about one hundred of his soldiers. The fiasco of the Tibet expedition shattered him both mentally and physically, and he either died of a consuming fever or was killed by his ambitious general Ali Mardan Khalji within three months of his return to Devkot (Dinajpur) in 1206 CE.

It is difficult to typify Bakhtiyar's relations with the sultans of Delhi. It is not known in whose name he struck coins or addressed Friday sermons, or the exact nature of his allegiance to Delhi. However, there is hardly any doubt that he conquered Bengal on his own and administered the occupied territory freely and independently.

Bakhtiyar's conquest of Bengal proved momentous. He founded a Muslim dominion in eastern India at a time when unrest and political turmoil in central Asia and dynastic changes in Delhi led to the immigration of Muslim chieftains, nobles, *ulamas* (persons learned in religious matters), and others into deltaic Bengal. With the arrival of new rulers, new people, and a new faith, the stage was set for changes in the society and the body politic of the country as a whole. More significant was the foundation of the Bengal Sultanate, which lasted for more than three centuries. The independent Bengal Sultans contributed enormously to the growth of an enlightened and prosperous Bengal during the medieval period.

Bengal Sultanate

The period after Muhammad Bakhtiyar's death in 1206 CE was marked by confusion and a disputed succession. His companions competed with one another for power at Lakhnauti. This internal dispute gave the rulers of Delhi an opportunity to exert influence in Bengal. The rivalry between two close associates of Bakhtiyar, Ali Mardan Khalji and Shiran Khalji, continued

until Shiran was killed by either a noble or the Hindu *zamindars*. Meanwhile Devkot became the center of the activities of the successors of Bakhtiyar Khalji, especially during the reign of Husamuddin Iwaz Khalji (1208-1210 and then again on 1212-1227 CE). After the death of Bakhtiyar Khalji (602 AH/1206 AD), his minister Shiran Khalji of Nagair usurped the power of Lakhnauti and attacked Ali Mardan's Iqta, Barsaul and arrested him. He was kept in confinement under the care of Baba Ispahani. He escaped his confinement and took shelter in Delhi. Ali Mardan soon returned to Bengal with the support of Qutbuddin Aibak of Delhi and captured power without any serious opposition. After the death of Qutbuddin Aibak, Ali Mardan declared himself the independent sultan of Bengal and assumed the title of Sultan Alauddin.

Alauddin's oppression of the Khalji nobles and his highhanded actions as an independent Sultan alienated most of his courtiers, who then united under the leadership of Husamuddin Iwaz Khalji. They killed Sultan Alauddin in 1212 CE and offered the throne of Lakhnauti to Husamuddin, who assumed the title of Sultan Ghyasuddin Iwaz Khalji. During his fifteen-year rule he firmly established Muslim rule in Bengal, expanded his territory, and succeeded in overcoming internal power politics. He moved his administrative headquarters from Devkot to Lakhnauti and built a navy to strengthen his position in riverine Bengal. His public works included the construction of roads and wide canals which saved both agricultural land and houses from floods. According to Minhaj-i-Siraj (in his medieval text *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*), Iwaz Khalji extended his territory to the South as far as the northern river and the rulers of Kamrup, Orissa, Tirhut, and eastern Bengal paid tribute to him. After consolidating his position, Iwaz Khalji turned to southeastern Bengal.

Sultan Samsuddin Iltutmish of Delhi did not allow the ruler of Bengal to be fully independent. After overcoming his initial problems, he sent a large army to conquer Bengal led by his eldest son Nasiruddin Mahmud. Nasiruddin Mahmud conquered Lakhnauti and killed Iwaz Khalji and many of his courtiers. After the defeat of Sultan Iwaz Khalji, the Muslim Kingdom of Bengal became a province of the Delhi Sultanate. However, the long distance from Delhi and the weakness of the central government encouraged the rulers of Lakhnauti to periodically declare independence or otherwise rule free from Delhi's intervention. For the rebellious actions of the local rulers, Ziauddin Barani, author of *Tarikh-i-Firuzshahi* mentioned that Delhi regarded Bengal as *Bulgakpur*, or the city of mutineers or defiance. This state of affairs continued for nearly half a century, until Ghiyasuddin

Balban succeeded in conquering the rebellious governor of Bengal in 1281. He appointed his son Bogra Khan as the ruler of Bengal and established Balban rule over the province.

Among the fifteen governors who ruled Bengal from 1227 to 1281, at least ten were slaves who rose to a high position through merit. As these governors were Turks, this period has been called the Turkish period of the Bengal Sultanate. Balban's invasion and conquest of Lakhnauti put an end to internal conflicts for a time, paving the way for the extension of the Muslim kingdom into south-west and south-east Bengal.

It has been stated that Ghiyasuddin Balban left the administration of Lakhnauti to his son Bogra Khan, who ruled from 1281 to 1291. He was assisted by two advisors nominated by his father. After his father's death in 1287, Bogra Khan rejected the offer of the Delhi Sultanate and instead became the virtually independent ruler of Bengal. He handed over the administration to his son Rokunuddin Kaikaus and retired from public life. Rokunuddin Kaikaus ruled for nine years from 1291 to 1300 CE. He had hardly any contact with Delhi, where the administration had passed to the Khaljis. The coins issued by Rokunuddin and the royal title of *Sikandar-us-Sani* (Alexander the second) that he assumed are perhaps an indication of his independence from Delhi. He was succeeded by Shamsuddin Firoz Shah, who ruled as the Sultan of Bengal for about two decades. From the testimony of coins and inscriptions, it is known that during his time he brought Sonargaon (Southeast Bengal), Satgaon (Southwest Bengal), Mymensingh, and Sylhet under his rule. Sylhet was conquered by the famous Sufi saint Shah Jalal and the sultan's general Nasiruddin, following which Shah Jalal and more than 300 of his disciples settled in Sylhet and began to preach Islam in the rural areas.

Following the death of Sultan Shamsuddin Firoz, his son Ghiyasuddin Bahadur captured the throne of Lakhnauti. His unilateral action caused discontent in his brothers, particularly the youngest, Nasiruddin Ibrahim, who sought aid from Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq of Delhi. This gave Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq an opportunity to invade Lakhnauti. He defeated Ghiyasuddin Bahadur and established his own authority over Bengal. Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq divided Bengal into three administrative regions: North and Northwest Bengal, administered from Lakhnauti; Southwest Bengal, administered from Satgaon; and East and Southeast Bengal, administered from Sonargaon. Each was placed under an administrator appointed by Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq. When he died on his way back to Delhi, his successor Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq changed the three rulers of Bengal, leading the

governor of Sonargaon to revolt against Delhi. In 1338, after Bahram Khan's (the governor of Sonargaon, East Bengal (now Bangladesh), from 1328 until 1337) death at Sonargaon, his armor bearer and close associate Fakhruddin captured power and proclaimed independence under the title Sultan Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah. This ushered in the foundation of the independent Sultanate of Bengal. After initial setbacks, Fakhruddin continued his rule in Sonargaon and extended his territory to Chittagong in the east. The independence declared in 1338 CE was retained for the following two centuries. During Fakhruddin's reign, the famous traveler Ibn Batuta of Morocco visited Bengal. He left an eyewitness account of Bengal and listed the prices of various items of daily necessity.

In 1342 CE, Haji Iliyas killed Alauddin Ali Shah, the ruler of Lakhnauti, and assumed the title of Sultan Shamsuddin Iliyas Shah. Under his rule (by 1352 CE) the three regions of Bengal were united for the first time under an independent sultanate. He was able to win over the local people, gave a distinct character to his administration and thus earned the title of *Shah-i-Bangalah* (Sultanate of Bengal). Encouraged by his initial successes, Iliyas Shah also sent expeditions to Tirhut, Nepal, Orissa, and Bihar. In Bihar he occupied Yuishi and Gorakpur, which were ruled by the Sultan in Delhi. At this Firuz Shah Tughlaq became annoyed and invaded Bengal to curb Iliyas Shah's power. After several encounters both parties agreed to sign a peace treaty. Iliyas Shah also subdued Tripura and part of Kamrup. Iliyas Shah's ability and courage were proved by his overwhelming authority over Bengal and his influence over the neighboring territories. He displayed matchless foresight in maintaining friendly relations with the rulers of Delhi and thus was able to strengthen the foundation of the independent Sultanate of Bengal. He maintained peace all over his territory. He was a pious ruler and highly respected the sufis and saints. He built a beautiful mosque in honor of Alaul Haq, the famous saint of his time.

Iliyas Shah's son Sikandar Shah succeeded him as Sultan. During his rule, Firuz Shah Tughlaq invaded Bengal for the second time. In his encounters with Sikandar Shah, no decisive result was achieved. Finally, both parties agreed to establish peace and exchanged valuable gifts. Sikandar Shah was recognized as an independent ruler and became a great patron of architecture. The Adina Masjid of Pandua built in the latter half of the fourteenth century bears testimony to this. He also seems to have taken a role as a religious leader, as indicated by his use of the title *Imam-ul-Azam* (the chief leader). During his 33-year rule, he maintained the unity of his territory and firmly ruled the whole country.

Sikander Shah was succeeded by his son Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah. After overcoming some initial problems, he devoted himself to the material and cultural development of his kingdom. Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah's patronage of poets and scholars, his devotion to the Sufi saints and Islamic culture, and his foreign relations earned him a distinct place in the history of medieval Bengal. His correspondence with the famous Persian poet Hafiz, his establishment of a madrasa in Mecca and a rest house in Madina, and the exchange of gifts and ambassadors between China and Bengal during his rule are well-known. During his reign a Hindu *zamindar*, Raja Ganesh, became powerful and captured power in 1415 probably by the successive planned killings of Azam Shah, his son and successor Saifuddin Hamza Shah, subsequently usurped the throne Shihab-uddin Baizid (a slave to his master Saifuddin Hamza Shah) and lastly Alauddin Feroz Shah.

Raja Ganesh and his family dominated the history of Bengal for about three decades. It is difficult to give a correct picture of Raja Ganesh from the scanty information that remains, though it is known that he was a landholder and courtier during the Iliyas Shahi Sultanate. It was through manipulation and conspiracy that he captured the throne of Bengal. The leading Muslim saint Nur-Kutub-al-Alam invited Sultan Ibrahim Sharki of Jaunpur (in present-day Uttar Pradesh) to invade Bengal. Ibrahim Sharki compelled Raja Ganesh to abdicate, converted Raja Ganesh's son Jadu to Islam, and placed the latter on the throne of Bengal with the name Jalaluddin Muhammad. Some sources indicate that Raja Ganesh made an attempt to regain the throne for the second time and held it for a brief period. However, no concrete evidence could be found in favor of this statement. During Jalaluddin Muhammad's time several mint towns including Firozabad, Sonargaon, Satgaon, Chittagong, and Fatehabad flourished. This shows that most of Bengal was controlled by him. He transferred his capital from Pandua to Gaur, where he and his family members were buried in the Ekdala Mausoleum—a building that has a unique design among the Muslim architecture of Bengal. After several quick successions, the courtiers and generals placed Nasir Khan (1246-1266), a descendant of Iliyas Shah, on the throne. Thus, the Iliyas Shahi dynasty was revived. Nasir Khan assumed the title of Nasiruddin Mahmud. He and his descendants ruled for about 45 years. The latter Iliyas Shahi rulers established peace throughout the country. This is evident from a number of buildings constructed during this period that includes mosques, *khanqahs* (house or abode of sufis), gates, palaces, and tombs.

Iliyas Shahi rulers firmly established Muslim rule in Bengal, and at the same time their independent status forced them to pursue an enlightened and liberal policy to gain the support of the local people. Their appointment of non-Muslims to high positions, veneration of vernacular languages, and patronage of local scholars gave a distinct character to Iliyas Shahi rule. Apart from the development of art and architecture, their promotion of religion and the Muslim culture led to the expansion of Islam in the rural areas of Bengal. Bengal was also linked with Muslim countries and with China. It seems that the Muslim military victory combined with this cultural liberalism gave rise, for the first time, to a new kind of society that ultimately shaped the identity of Bengal.

During the reign of Barbak Shah and his son Yusuf Shah, the Habshis (slaves brought mostly from Abyssinia) became prominent by virtue of their numbers and the positions they held over the years. Taking advantage of the weakness of the last Iliyas Shahi ruler Jalaluddin Fateh Shah, his palace guard Sultan Shahjada killed him and captured the throne in 1486, taking the title Barbak Shah. Thus ended Ilias Shahi rule and in its place Habshi rule began. The Habshi rule lasted for six years from 1487 to 1493. Their rule constituted one of the darkest periods of Bengal's history, as it was marked by conspiracies, rebellions, murder, and the seizing of power. Shamsuddin Muzzaffar Shah, the last of the Habshi rulers, became unpopular because of his cruelty and oppression. Anarchy reigned supreme everywhere in Bengal. Amid these unsettled conditions, nobles and courtiers revolted and killed Shamsuddin Muzzaffar Shah. With his death, Habshi rule came to an end.

A powerful courtier named Syed Husain then established himself as the sultan, taking the title Alauddin Husain Shah. On his assumption to power, the Husain Shahi period of Bengal history began; four sultans from this dynasty ruled Bengal from 1493 to 1538. It is known that Husain Shah's family originated from Arabia and settled in Murshidabad (West Bengal). He worked under Muzaffar Shah at Gaur and gradually rose to the position of a minister. At the outset, he suppressed the rebellious elements in the army and created a new security force in place of the *paiks* (infantrymen with spears/pikes) who had participated in the killing of earlier sultans. The Habshis were eventually driven from the country. He appointed local Hindus and Muslim noblemen from Turkey, Arabia, and Afghanistan to high government posts.

Husain Shah also extended his territory into North and South Bihar and to Kamta-Kamrup (modern region situated between two rivers,

bear testimony to his passion for architecture. He created a mosque in Pandua in honor of the Sufi Nur Kutub-Alam as well as contributed land and money for his *darga*. His tolerance for the followers of other religions earned him the respect of Shri Chaitanya Dev, the founder of Gaudiya Vaishnavism. Worship of "Satya Pir" (a belief system formed by the fusion of Islam and other local religions) in his time is another example of his liberal views. He wanted to bring the Hindus and Muslims closer. Thus the glories of Husain Shahi Bengal included territorial expansion, administrative stability, and the development of the economy, literature, religion, and architecture. The rulers needed local support and allegiances against foreign invasion. To create a popular base they appointed local people to high administrative positions. The political stability thus created led to the success of the rulers in all fields. Their military success resulted in the inclusion within Bengal of the countries up to the confluence of the Ganges in the West, Chitagong in the east, and Kamrup (Assam) in the north. It was this period which witnessed the beginning of significant forces that would deeply affect the political and economic history of Bengal. Between the first event of the Europeans and end of Mughal rule, this period saw the historical processes, which shaped the life of the country for centuries to come. "Mughal rule touched only the outer fringe of Bengal politics and the European trade was yet to have a proper beginning. But the period in question showed the signs of a new Bengal to be brought into existence through the working of those forces" (Tarafdar 1965: 351).

Within less than a century of the foundation of Muslim rule, the principality of Lakhnauti expanded to include the regions on either side of the Bhagirathi River. As a result of the disintegration of Tughlaq rule, independent kingdoms came into being in different parts of the subcontinent, including Bengal. The first phase of Bengal's independence was represented by Iliyas Shahi rule. The rulers who had to depend upon regional patriotism in the process of countering the authority of Delhi adopted secular policies for their administration. In the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, a considerable number of non-Muslims held high posts under Muslim rulers and formed the landed aristocracy of the country. Thus the sultans made significant contributions to the growth of a Hindu middle class "with all its economic and cultural paraphernalia."

With the foundation of the independent sultanate, ports like Satgaon, Sonargaon, and Chittagong came into prominence. These, together with a number of minting towns, greatly encouraged Bengal's maritime trade

with the outside world. Thus Muslim rule brought Bengal "from [the] rural to urban phase of civilisation based on the introduction of [a] money economy" (Tarafdar 1965: 30).

Society and Culture

Bakhtiyar Khalji's conquest of Bengal and establishment of the Muslim Kingdom led to the growth of a Muslim society. Before the Muslim rule, the population of Bengal was composed mainly of Hindus, Buddhists, aboriginals, and a few Jains. Subsequently new elements like Parsees, Portuguese, and Armenians were added to the population. The aboriginals, though constituting a sizable population, were not considered to belong to mainstream society. The Jain population gradually declined. (Jainism accepted the Brahmanical doctrine of *karma* and "rebirth" but rejected the authority of the *Vedas*, the caste system, and the practice of animal sacrifice. By and large they considered themselves Hindus, differing from them only in certain philosophical and theological aspects). With the fall of the Buddhist Pala rule and the ascendancy of the Senas and their aggressive Brahmanical domination, Buddhism quickly declined and eventually it is said that it disappeared from the land of its birth. However, it still counts one third of the population of the world as followers. In Bengal, Hindus outnumbered the other religious communities and were also politically and economically advanced. The caste system dominated their social life, including their manners, morals, and thoughts. The four hereditary occupational groups, namely the Brahmans (the priestly class), Ksatriyas (the political and military groups), Vaishas (in charge of trade, agriculture, and commerce), and Sudras (service groups) had existed for a long time. Each class was separated from the others by obligatory rules, and social contacts in any form were prohibited. The oppression of the lower castes by the Brahmins had a demoralizing effect on the existing society.

After the conquest of Bengal by Bakhtiyar Khalji in the early thirteenth century, the Muslim population of Bengal began to grow, both through local converts and by Muslims who came from outside and settled in Bengal. The Muslim rulers, their relatives, officials, and the thousands of soldiers who came in the wake of the Muslim invasion ultimately settled in the region. Soon many other immigrants from Turkey, Iran, Abyssinia, Central Asia, Arabia, Afghanistan, and upper India joined them. These immigrants were joined by the hundreds of sufis who arrived in Bengal with their followers.

The Muslim rulers played a significant part in building the Muslim society in Bengal. The aim of the Sultans was not only to continue Muslim rule, but also to build institutions and initiate works that would help Muslim society and culture. One of their first acts was the construction of mosques. As places of prayer—one of the fundamental pillars of Islamic faith—mosques were the most important feature of Muslim society and culture. They were built in locations where it would be convenient for the people to perform their religious duties. The Adina Mosque in Pandua, Khan Jahan Mosque at Bagerhat, and Jafar Khan Mosque at Tribeni are early examples. The sultans also established *maktabs* (elementary school) and *madrasas* for imparting religious education. *Madrasas* were also established by private initiatives, with or without government assistance. Many *madrasas* maintained residential accommodations, providing food and lodgings for both teachers and students. The sultans also offered facilities to pilgrims to visit Mecca and Medina during the Hajj. Some of the sultans and their officers were noted for their learning and proficiency in the Qur'an, *Hadith* (tradition of the Prophet), and Islamic law. They in turn encouraged the promotion of similar education for their subjects. The sultans' benevolent activities, such as the construction of wells, excavation of tanks, and grant of lands to maintain almshouses, were aimed at alleviating the distress of the common people.

The learned people known as the *ulama* occupied a high position in Muslim society. They imparted religious education in many ways, including lessons on the Islamic sciences *Fiqh* (theory or philosophy of Islamic law) and *Hadith* and upheld the Muslim religious tradition through their activities. The *ulamas* were paid in a number of ways, including stipends, land grants, and the provision of facilities for visiting holy places.

A large number of Sufis came to Bengal. According to local traditions, some even came before the Muslim conquest. There is hardly any town or locality in Bengal where a Sufi did not come and settle. Their contribution to the preaching and expansion of Islam in rural Bengal was significant: first, by extending help to expand Muslim political power; second, through their influence over the ruling classes, which provided an additional attraction to the common people; third, by giving religious instruction to everybody who gathered around their *khanqahs*; and finally, through their influence over society as spiritual leaders and comforters of people in distress, which spread among the masses and gradually attracted converts to the new faith.

The sultans, Muslim scholars, and sufi saints who migrated to Bengal contributed enormously to the formation and growth of the Muslim

society and culture in medieval Bengal. The main tenets of Islam—its unqualified faith in one universal God, the fraternity of Muslims and equal status of people, accountability and duties to God and to creation—attracted many local people who had become suspicious of their own religion or who were oppressed under the strict regulations and practices of the caste system.

The spread of Islam and the formation of Muslim society under the Bengal Sultanate did not, however, go unhindered. Reactions took different forms: first, people accepted the new faith, which they considered to have a manifest ideology of equity; second, the orthodox section adhered to their own faith, right or wrong; and finally, the establishment of Islam created an urge among a section of enlightened people to reform their religion, taking the good sides of Islam and shunning what they considered to be the bad sides of their own religion. The best example in the early 16th century is the preaching of a reformed version of Vaishnavism by Chaitanya Dev, who ignored the caste rules, advocated for the equality of all worshippers, and emphasized the importance of *bhakti* or ardent love for and devotion to one God.

These interactions between Islam and local Hinduism continued throughout the Muslim rule in Bengal, spurred on occasion by the liberal patronage policies of some Muslim rulers. Alauddin Husain Shah's liberal policy encouraged social and religious reform movements such as the one pioneered by Shri Chaitanya. Years of association with non-Muslims who far outnumbered them and with "half converts" from Hinduism, Muslims also deviated from their original faith and became Bengalised by bringing Islamic elements near local practices as well as by directly accepting some local elements. The preparation of *Tazia* to observe the Muharram festival in the way of Durga sacrifice and Rath Jatra, the worship of Panchpir, Satya Pir, Saint Worship, and *tirtha* or visits to the shrines of sufis are some examples of this trend towards the liberalization of society. Muslims also subconsciously imitated the caste system, creating a sense of aristocracy among upper class Muslims and ignoring the Islamic idea of fraternity and equality.

The sultans of Bengal attached great importance to the provision of education, which was considered part of their religious duties. As a result there was remarkable progress in learning and knowledge in medieval Bengal, featuring the contributions of both Muslim and Hindu scholars. The translation of Sanskrit works into Bangla added significance to literary life. Lakhnauti, Sonargaon, Nagor, Mandaram, Rangpur, and Chittagong

became centers of Islamic learning; Nabadwip, Sylhet, and Bishnupur were developed as centers of Sanskrit and Hindu religious studies. The development of the Bengali language and literature was significant during the sultanate period, especially because it integrate the Bengali-speaking territory and population. The Bengali language was given a respectable place in both court and civil society. Sultans Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah and Alauddin Husain liberally patronized Bengali poets and literature in the effort to promote the Bangla language. A large body of literature grew up around the life and teachings of Chaitanya. This brought forth a new social and cultural understanding between Hindus and Muslims in building a common platform of the two communities of Bengal.

Bengali society under the sultanate was by and large divided into a number of classes. The ruling class was at the top and slaves were at the bottom. Between these two classes there were the aristocrats, consisting of high officials, big landlords, and members of the nobility; the landed gentry generally known as *zamindars*, which formed the common landed aristocracy; the sizable middle class, including teachers, clerks, traders, officers, and other professional groups who earned a living through physical and intellectual work; and the large group of commoners, consisting of cultivators, small manufacturers, shopkeepers, agricultural and industrial workers, and other lower-class employees. Slaves came from several sources: first, prisoners of war, who were generally converted into slaves; and second, the sale of children by poor parents or guardians due to extreme pecuniary distress. A large number of slaves were also imported from foreign countries such as Abyssinia, Central and West Asia, Armenia, and Georgia. The Hindu social structure was mostly dictated by caste, though the policies pursued by the independent sultans had some liberalizing effects on Hindu society: educated non-Brahman Hindus could also be appointed to higher administrative positions and by their influence cross the caste barrier. In the Muslim social structure, the sultans and their family formed the upper class; the Sheikhs, Syeds, Mughals, and Pathans formed the traditional aristocratic groups. The *ulama*, *mashaikh* (spiritual guidesul), and professional groups like *muftis* (Muslim legal experts), *muhtasibs* (supervisor of markets and trade in medieval Islamic countries), and other officials belonged to the enlightened group; below them there were the common people, servants, and slaves. According to Islamic principles, Muslim society should not be structured like this, but it seems that the influence of the Hindu caste system prevailed all over the country.

During the Bengal Sultanate, Muslim society expanded. This period was the formative phase of the political and socio-cultural life of Bengal. The identity of Bengal and Bengali people began to appear with the establishment of the independent sultanate in Bengal. It also contributed to the growth of the distinctive characteristics and institutions of the Bengali people. The interaction of Islam and Hinduism in practical life led to the "syncretistic tradition" in Bengali society. The Bengali language brought about a unique sense of cohesion in the people. There was also economic prosperity due to internal stability and the extension of external trade based on indigenous manufactured and agricultural products. The unity that was achieved under the independent sultanate provided the basis for the popular strength and solidarity of Bengal. The Bengal Sultanate, therefore, was the most constructive period in the history of Bengal. The independence and unity of Bengal, together with the strong civil and military administration with popular support, economic and educational development, overwhelming influence of the Bangla language, international relations, and secular policies based on religious tolerance thus left a precious legacy for posterity.

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The Mughal Rule: Politics, Society and Culture

Abdul Karim

Muslim rule in Bengal continued for about five and a half centuries, from Bakhtiyar Khalji's conquest in 1204-05 to the Battle of Plassey in 1757. After Plassey, the British East India Company became the controlling power in Bengal's politics, although the administration was carried on in the name of puppet *nawabs* for a few more years. The period of Muslim rule is divided into two phases: Sultanate and Mughal. Sultanate rule ended on 12 July 1576, when in the battle of Rajmahal the last Afghan Sultan Daud Khan Karrani was defeated by Khan Jahan, a general of the great Mughal emperor Akbar. Daud Karrani was beheaded and Tanda, the capital (located in present-day Malda district), was occupied. This meant the end of the Sultan and the Sultanate, but the Mughal conquest of Bengal was still far away. The Mughal army controlled and established authority over a small area surrounding the capital city; they kept their supply and baseline to Delhi open and safe, but the rest of Bengal was controlled by independent and semi-independent military Chiefs, Afghans, and Bengali Bhuiyans and Rajas, both Muslim and Hindu. Sending general after general, Akbar made strenuous efforts to bring the whole of Bengal under his control, but failed. His dream of conquering Bengal was fulfilled during the reign of his son Jahangir by a young, energetic *subahdar* named Islam Khan Chisti.

Besides the chiefs and Bhuiyans, Bengal's climate and geography also offered great resistance to Mughal aggression. Bengal is a country where the monsoon prevails for almost half of the year. There are many rivers and water-channels, both deep and shallow. In fact, there is a river every 25 kilometers or so. Bengal is dominated by two big rivers, the Ganges and the Brahmaputra—the former emerging out of the Himalayas and running through upper India into Bengal; the latter flowing out of the Himalayas and entering Bengal through Assam and Kamrup. The Ganges

bifurcates on entering Bengal; one stream flowing to the east takes the name Padma and meets other rivers and channels before falling into the sea; the other flowing to the south takes the name Bhagirathi and, joining with other rivers and channels, falls into the sea after passing through Hooghly and Kolkata. The Brahmaputra was also a mighty river (now it has lost much of its former glory): flowing southwards through a labyrinth of channels including the mighty Padma, it took the name of Meghna as it flows down to the sea. In North Bengal there are also the Mahananda, Tista, Karatoya, and Atreyi and in south Bengal the Bhairab, Madumati, and Arial Khan—all distributories of the Ganges. Surma, Gomati, and the two Feni rivers are important waterways in eastern Bengal—the last two forming the border between Bengal and the Kingdom of Arakan during the Mughal period.

The natural geography of Bengal posed barriers to the Mughal conquest of Bengal, but the political geography also offered no small barrier. On the eve of the Mughal conquest Bengal was occupied by a large number of independent, semi-independent Bhuiyans, Rajas, and Afghan chiefs. Taking advantage of the change of government at the center and the resulting instability during the twilight of the Afghan Sultanate, they established their own authority in different parts of Bengal. There were, for example, Bir Hammir of Bishnupur (Bankura-Birbhum), Shams Khan of Pachet and Salim Khan of Hijh (Medinipur area); Pitambar, Ananta of Chilajawar, and Illah Bakhsh of Alaipur, all in North Bengal centering on Rajshahi; Raja Pratapaditya of Jessore, Raja Mukunda and his son Raja Satrajit of Bhushna (in the eastern part of Jessore); Raja Kandarpa Narayan and his son Raja Ram Chandra of Bakla (Bakerganj); Raja Lakshman Manikya and Ananta Manikya of Bhulna (Noakhali); Khwaja Usman Afghan and his brothers at Bukainagar (Gauripur, greater Mymensingh); Bayazid Karrani of Sylhet. Usman and Bayazid were both Afghan chiefs. Then there were the Bhuiyans of Bhati, whose chief in Akbar's time was Isa Khan Masnad-i-Ala and in Jahangir's time was Isa Khan's son Musa Khan Masnad-i-Ala. Other prominent Bhuiyans of Bhati included Chand Rai and his brother Kedar Rai of Bikrampur and the Ghazis of Bhowal.

The Khwaja Usmans were four brothers, the sons of Isa Khan (not to be confused with Isa Khan Masnad-i-Ala of Bhati) a minister of Qatlu Khan of Orissa. Along with his brothers and other Afghans, Usman put up stubborn resistance to the Mughals in Orissa, but after their defeat were banished by the Mughals to Bengal. Solaiman was the eldest; upon his death in Bengal, the leadership fell upon the second brother Usman.

The brothers travelled through Satgaon and Bhushna and ultimately established authority at Bokainagar (near present-day Mymensingh).

Raja Pratapaditya was the son of Sri Hari, one of Daud Karrani's ministers. At the Battle of Rajmahal both Sri Hari and his colleague Qatlu Khan sided with the Mughals and thus Sri Hari was given the *zamindari* of a big estate in Jessore. The Rajas of Bhushna, Bakla, and Bhulua were all hereditary chiefs who offered nominal submission to the authority in the capital and thus enjoyed undisturbed succession.

The great enemies of the Mughals were the Bara Bhuiyans, who resisted the Mughal advance into Bengal for several decades. The chief of the Bara Bhuiyans was Isa Khan during Akbar's reign and Musa Khan during Jahangir's. Both assumed leadership of the Bhuiyans and were conferred the title of Masnad-i-Ala. Isa Khan was the son of Kalidas Gajdani, a Bias Rajput, who was said to have been a *diwan* of Sultan Ghias-ud-din Mahmud Shah of Bengal (1533-38). He married the daughter of the Sultan, embraced Islam, and took the name Sulaiman Khan. During the Reign of Islam Shah Sur (Salim Shah), the son of Sher Shah, Sulaiman Khan rebelled and was killed. Isa and his brother Ismail were sent to exile in Iran, but were later permitted to return, at which time Isa Khan took up the management of his father's estate. He owed allegiance to the Karrani Sultans; after the fall of the Karranis, he joined with other Bhuiyans and fought against the Mughals until his death in 1599 CE. A Mughal military officer named Masum Khan Kabuli also joined with Isa Khan. In 1580 the Mughal captains in Bengal revolted and set up a rebel government. Akbar suppressed this rebellion and re-established his authority, but although others submitted, Musum Khan Kabuli chose to remain a rebel. He assumed independence, but died in 1599 leaving a son, Mirza Mumin, who joined the Bara Bhuiyans. Kedar Rai of Sripur-Bikrampur also put up a stubborn resistance to the Mughals. He fought a few hotly contested battles with Raja Mansingh, Akbar's *subahdar* of Bengal. Kedar Rai received mortal wounds in one such battle and later died in 1602. Although the leaders were dead, their successors continued their struggle during the reign of Jahangir, until finally the Bara Bhuiyans were made to submit by Jahangir's *subahdar* of Bengal Islam Khan Chisti.

Jahangir's first few years saw little Mughal advance into Bengal, but with the appointment of Islam Khan Chisti as *subahdar* in 1608 the situation completely changed. The new *subahdar* claimed noble birth; he was the grandson of Shaikh Salim Chishti, a sufi saint of Fatehpur Sikri. The relations between the families of the emperor and Shaikh were

most cordial. Although the *subahdar* was young and inexperienced, the emperor's choice could not have been better. Immediately upon taking up his post in the then-capital Rajmahal, Islam Khan Chisti drew up an accomplished plan of operation. He decided to transfer the capital from Rajmahal, situated at the western end of the *subah*, to a suitably strategic place in the east. He knew that the greatest enemy of the Mughals were the Bara Bhuiyans and the Afghans under Khwaja Usman—all of whose strength lay in Eastern Bengal. For this reason Islam Khan decided to transfer the capital to the heart of Bhati area, ultimately choosing Dhaka as the new capital. Because Bengal was a riverine country where Mughal cavalry was ineffective for almost half of the year, he strengthened the Mughal navy; at his request, the emperor sent Ihtimam Khan to place the navy on a sound footing. The Bara Bhuiyans were strong in river warfare, so the Mughal navy was organized so as to annihilate the local flotillas of war boats.

The *subahdar* started from Rajmahal with his boats and artillery, moving towards Bhati. On the way, he subjugated the *zamindars* and chiefs on both sides of the Ganges. On reaching the heart of Bhati, he declared Dhaka the new capital; from there, he subjugated the Bara Bhuiyans in about two years and defeated one by one the Rajas of Jessore, Bakla, and Bhulua, Khwaja Usman Afghan and his brothers, and Bayazid Karrani of Sylhet. By the end of 1612, the whole of Bengal except Chittagong was brought under the Mughal control. The next year he also occupied the neighboring kingdom of Kamrup.

Formerly, if the Mughal general occupied an area, the Rajas and *zamindars*/Bhuiyans who surrendered were reinstated in their positions with the promise that they would remain loyal and pay tribute. But as soon as the Mughal army retraced their steps, the subjugated Bhuiyans, Chiefs, and Rajas would shake off this allegiance, gather fresh strength, and become independent. Islam Khan examined the situation very carefully and did not allow the defeated chiefs to return to their previous stations. Instead, they were forced into Mughal service and compelled to fight against their brethren. This policy was extremely effective; the power of the Rajas, Bhuiyans or *zamindars*, and chiefs was so crippled that they could never again raise their heads. Thus was the Mughal authority in Bengal consolidated.

Ibrahim Khan Fath-i-Jang, another *subahdar* of Jahangir, conquered Tripura and ousted the King from his throne, but within a couple of years Tripura regained its independence. The rebel Prince Shah Jahan came

to Bengal and remained there for a few months. After his flight to the Deccan, Jahangir's authority was re-established.

Shah Jahan's first *subahdar* of Bengal Quasim Khan did an excellent service by expelling the Portuguese from Hooghly in 1632 CE. The Portuguese had established a settlement at Hooghly around 1580 with the permission of the Emperor Akbar, but on the plea of trade, they indulged in unlawful activities, and Hooghly under them was going to be an *imperium in imperio*, so their power had to be curbed. Although the Portuguese were allowed to return soon after their banishment, their former power and glory were gone.

During the *subahdari* of Prince Shah Shuja, Bengal enjoyed peace for 20 years, from 1639-1658, but when the emperor Shah Jahan fell ill the Mughal Empire plunged into a civil war in which all four princes—Dara, Shuja, Aurangzeb, and Murad—took part. Shuja enthroned himself at Rajmahal; he fought first against Dara, then against Aurangzeb, but was finally defeated in 1660 and took shelter with the king of Arakan where he was brutally murdered in 1661 CE.

Mir Jumla, who had defeated and driven Shuja out of Bengal, was then appointed *subahdar*. Born of humble origins in Iran, Mir Muhammad Said—more famous in history by his surname Mir Jumla—came to Golconda in South India in the service of an Iranian merchant. Later, he made a fortune for himself. He engaged in the diamond business and gradually rose to be a merchant of name and fame; his diamonds were counted by the sackful and he also owned many ships. He was appointed *wazir* of the Sultanate of Golconda, but later he moved to the Mughal empire to be in the service of Shah Jahan and then of Aurangzeb. In Bengal, Mir Jumla's chief contribution was the conquest of Assam, but he fell seriously ill in the course of the campaign. He tried to return but died on the way. His conquered possessions in Assam also went out of hand.

The next great Mughal *subahdar* of Bengal was Shaista Khan, who was in Bengal for about 22 years with a short break when Azam Khan Koka (Fidai Khan) and Prince Muhammad Azam became the *subahdars*. Shaista Khan came of a noble family; his father was Asaf Khan, who was also father of Mumtaz Mahal, a consort of Shah Jahan. Asaf Khan was the son of Itimid-ud-dawla (Mirza Ghias Beg) and the brother of Nur Jahan, Jahangir's queen. Shaista Khan came to Bengal at the age of 63 with several adult sons; with their help and co-operation, he ruled Bengal ably and with distinction. But his great fame in Bengal comes from his conquest of Chittagong. With the aid of Portuguese pirates, the Magh king of Arakan

had been attacking Bengal, leaving the coastal regions desolate, burning and plundering property, and enslaving men, women, and children. Through careful policies Shaista Khan won over the Portuguese pirates and conquered Çhittagong with their help. Arakan never again dared to invade Bengal. Shaista Khan was kind and liberal; he spent on the welfare of the poor, indigent, and religious and built mosques, bridges, and *sarais*. In his time the price of grain was extremely low, so rice was sold at 8 maunds per rupee. He was gentle, amiable, and humane and is therefore described as a pattern of excellence.

After Shaista Khan, Khan Jahan Bahadur had a short tenure as *subahdar*, followed by Ibrahim Khan. During Ibrahim Khan's tenure Shova Singh, a *zamindar* of Chandrakona in Midnapur district, revolted and joined with Rahim Khan, an Afghan leader of Orissa, to plunder properties in an extensive territory including the port of Hooghly. *Subahdar* Ibrahim Khan had a scholarly disposition and failed to take any measures against the miscreants. Aurangzeb recalled him and appointed his own grandson Muhammad Azim-ud-din (entitled Azim-ush-shan). The rebels were punished, but in his desire to amass wealth he allowed the British East India Company to purchase the three villages of Sutanuti, Govindapur, and Kalikata from their lawful owners. Thus the English laid the foundation of Calcutta (now Kolkata), which later played an important part in the culture and history not only of Bengal, but also of India.

Following the death of Aurangzeb in 1707, and with the resultant war of succession and the ambitions of the Mughal princes and nobility, the central government of the Mughals turned feeble and fragile, giving rise to provincial kingdoms. In Bengal Murshid Quli Khan, the last great imperial officer, was able to place himself at the head of every branch of administration. He sent the imperial revenue regularly and thus kept the emperor and his ministers happy. Murshid Quli Khan was the *subahdar* of Bengal and Orissa and the *diwan* of Bihar. He was also given the lofty title of Mustamin-ul-Mulk Ala-ud-dowla Jafar Khan Nasirinasir Jang. He became the de facto ruler of Bengal, but the emperor and central government continued to place confidence in him. The appointment of subordinate officers was made through his recommendation. He became the focus of attention in the provinces. Members of his family, his relatives, and his favorites were given preference in all branches of administration; this is why his period of administration is known as *niabat* or the Nawabi period. It was Murshid Quli Khan who transferred the capital from Dhaka to Murshidabad.

Murshid Quli Khan died in 1727 leaving no male heir. He hoped that his grandson (son of his daughter) Asadullah, entitled Sarfaraz Khan, would succeed him and he had accordingly recommended his name to the emperor. Sarfaraz's father Shujauddin Muhammad Khan was holding the post of deputy *subahdar* of Orissa at the time of Murshid Quli Khan's death. He forestalled his son's acceptance of the position and occupied the Masnad (throne) of Murshidabad. He was also appointed the *subahdar* of Bihar and from this time Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa came under one person in both *nizamat* and *diwani* administration. Shuja-ud-din ruled peacefully for more than a decade until his death in 1739. To improve the administration, he divided the three provinces of Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa into four divisions and created a council of advisors consisting of Alivardi Khan (the deputy *subahdar* of Bihar), Haji Ahmad (Alivardi's elder brother), Diwan Rai Rayan Alam Chand, and the great banker Jagat Seth. The Hindus were already getting higher jobs from the time of Murshid Quli Khan, but now they were allowed entry into the advisory council. The two brothers Alivardi Khan and Haji Ahmad proved to be great conspirators and they appointed Haji Ahmad's three adult sons to key positions like *faujdar* and *diwan*. When Sarfaraz Khan sat on the *masnad* after his father's death, Alivardi conspired against him with other members of the council and marched from Patna at the head of an army. In the encounter that followed Sarfaraz Khan was killed and Alivardi occupied the Masnad of Murshidabad.

Alivardi Khan, entitled Mahabat Jang, was 64 when he sat on the Masnad of Murshidbad in 1740. He died in 1756 at the age of 80. Even at this old age, he ruled vigorously. He had to suppress several rebellions including that of Rustam Jang (Mirza Lutfullah, Murshid Quli Khan II), the son-in-law of Shujauddin Muhammad Khan. Rustam Jang did not submit to Alivardi but fought against him and was defeated. His general Mir Habib then invited the Marathas to invade Orissa. The Maratha menace posed the greatest problem for Alivardi Khan, and the repeated Maratha incursions seriously damaged the prestige of the Nawab, who ultimately had to buy peace by ceding Orissa to the Marathas and promising to pay them 12 lakh rupees annually. Alivardi had no male child; his three daughters were married to his three nephews, the sons of Haji Ahmad. They were given higher posts: the eldest, Nawazish Muhammad, was entitled Shalhamat Jang and appointed the Naib Nazim of Dhaka; the second, Said Ahmad Khan was appointed in Purnia with the title of Saalat Jang; and the third, Zain-ud-din Ahmad, was appointed to Patna with the

title of Khan. They were known by their stations: Dhaka *nawab*; Purnia *nawab*; and Patna *nawab*. All of his nephews died before Alivardi did; these breavements, the rebellions, and the Maratha menace all caused terrible depression in the mind of the Nawab. His health was seriously affected, and he died in April 1756.

Alivardi Khan was survived by four grandsons: the adult Shawkat Jang and child Mirza Ramzani, both sons of his second daughter; and Sirajuddaula and Mirza Mahdi, sons of his third and youngest daughter. His eldest daughter Meherun-Nisa, alias Ghasiti Begum, was childless. Sirajuddaula was Alivardi's darling; as he was born in the year Alivardi received the post of deputy *subahdari* of Bihar, Siraj was regarded as a bringer of good fortune.

After his grandfather's death Siraj occupied the *masnad*, but he soon found himself surrounded by enemies. His own ambitious aunt Ghasiti Begum was his greatest enemy; then there was Shawkat Jang, his cousin from Purnia; and finally there was Mir Muhammad Jafar Ali Khan (Mir Jafar), the commander of the army. Ghasiti Begum brought-up Siraj's brother Akram-ud-dowla from childhood, and cherished the idea of ruling the country from behind the veil through her adopted son. When Akram-ud-dowla died before Alivardi, Ghasiti Begum favored Shawkat Jang. The latter was ambitious but worthless, and was defeated and killed in an encounter in the battle of Manihari against Siraj. Then there were the Hindu officers and bankers, particularly Jagat Seth, who had been raised to a position of influence by Alivardi Khan and his predecessors. They had nothing to lose from the win or loss of any of the contending parties, and knew how to manage each and every turn of events in their favour.

Sirajuddaula succeeded to the *masnad* at the age of 23. He first paid attention to streamlining the administration and, in so doing, he created enemies and faced opposition from different quarters. He asked Raj Ballabh to clear the accounts of the Dhaka Niabat (deputy of the Nawab in charge of administration), because he was the *pishkar* there. When he failed to clear the accounts he was confined, but his son Krishna Ballabh escaped to Calcutta with his family and treasures. Siraj asked the British East India Company not to give shelter to the fugitives, who were his subjects and were under trial, but the English refused to hand over the criminals to the Nawab's government. The English also committed other offences against the Nawab and began the fortification of Kolkata without permission. No government could tolerate such insolence, so Siraj came

out of Murshidabad and attacked Calcutta. The English were driven out and took shelter in ships out of the Nawab's reach, but they came back with reinforcements from Madras. The Company secretly entered into a pact with the Nawab's disaffected officials including Mir Jafar, Raj Ballabh, Rai Durlabh, and the banker Jagat Seth. According to the secret treaty, the English agreed to place Mir Jafar on the *masnad* by force, and in return Mir Jafar agreed to grant territorial, financial, and trade facilities to the English. Armed with the treaty, Robert Clive marched against the Nawab and took his position at the plain of Plassey. The Nawab also came out with his army, but when the Nawab's army was engaged in a fierce battle and the English were about to be defeated, Mir Jafar advised the Nawab to postpone the battle for the next day. While the Nawab ordered his army to cease hostilities for the day, Mir Jafar sent secret information to Clive to launch a vigorous attack. The Nawab's soldiers were taken aback. Many had already laid down their arms to rest; some who turned back could not withstand the enemy attack. Thus the Nawab was defeated due to the treachery of Mir Jafar. He fled but was brought back as a captive, and later was beheaded. Robert Clive took Mir Jafar by the hand and placed him on the Masnad of Murshidabad. In fact, there was hardly any change—one *nawab* made way for another, as had happened many times before—but in practice the English became the controller of affairs, and step-by-step sovereignty passed to their hands.

New Forces at Work

With the emergence of the Mughals in Bengal, the country witnessed new forces in administrative, social, economic, and cultural life. These forces transformed Bengal's life and thought. Unlike the previous period, when it had enjoyed independence, Bengal now became a part of the centralized Mughal Empire, under one administration, one law, one official language, one uniform official cadre, and one uniform currency. Emperor Akbar divided the empire into several provinces called *subahs*. While doing so, due consideration was given to geographical feature, natural boundaries and language. Bengal became a *subah* in which the Bengali-speaking people were enclosed by well-demarcated natural boundaries. During the Mughal conquest of Bengal, the capital was located at Tanda, 15 miles southeast of Malda and now washed away by the river; before the end of Akbar's reign, Subahdar Man Singh had transferred the capital to Rajmahal and renamed it Akbarnagar. In the reign of Jahangir, Subahdar Islam Khan Chisti transferred the capital to Dhaka, which was renamed Jahangirnagar, and

deities such as Manasa, Chandi (Caṇḍī), and Kalika; this literature came to be known as *Mangals*.

The Bengali language acquired a literary status during the Sultanate period. Famous literary works were written by Hindu poets, such as *Srikrishnakirtan* (Śrikṛṣṇakīrtan) by Chandidas (Caṇḍīdāsa), the *Ramayana* by Krittibas Ojha, the *Srikrishnavijay* (Śrikṛṣṇavijay) by Maladhar Basu Gunaraj Khan, and the *Mahabharata* (Mahābhārata) by Kavindra Paremeshwar. Towards the end of the Sultanate period, Muslims also began to write Bengali poems. A large number of books were written during the Mughal period, books on the *Ramayana*, *Mahabharata*, *Mangal Kavyas*, and *Chaitanya Kavyas*. Under the influence of Persian literature, Muslim writers introduced romantic literature. Apart from these great literary works, folk poetry composed by village bards was collected in large numbers. These were sung in leisurely social gatherings by both Hindus and Muslims. All these were romantic tales, some based on historical events.

The Mughals were foreigners who drained Bengal's treasure and took it to their own capitals, but Mughal rule appeared as a blessing for Bengal. They established peace, good government, and discipline, and freed the people from the oppression of the pirates. The people prospered and literary activities gained momentum. Because the Mughals were liberal in religious matters, non-Muslims could also practice their religion freely, without any interference. In the words of Sir Jadunath Sarkar: "The period of imperial Mughal rule over Bengal witnessed the working of certain new forces which have completely transformed Bengali life and thought and whose influence is still operating in the province."

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